

ning to sense that putting my orders into the pits was like holding up bread to the seagulls.

Mr. Flippen stamped in my yen purchase, offered his congratulations, and we repeated the process with the deutsche marks. At the deutsche-mark pit my transaction was handled by Ron Englund, a hefty and affable fellow. He quickly bought one September 48 deutsche-mark call while simultaneously selling the September 49 call, thus creating the straddle—whatever that was.

Since Mr. Englund wasn't busy, we had a brief chat at the edge of his pit. He'd worked as a telephone repairman, fought in Vietnam, and then tried the pizza business before joining Lind-Waldock. There he'd started out in gold and drifted into deutsche marks. In his spare time, he helped raise three children, sang in a church choir, and umpired at Little League baseball games. One thing he never did was invest in deutsche-mark options, preferring to make a modest living by executing orders for high-rollers like me. "When I gamble I always lose," he confided. "I learned that about myself a long time ago." I admired his self-discipline, though with all the fantastic fortunes being made around him, I felt he was missing out.

We took our deutsche-mark spread, logged it in at the order desk, then marched on to the live-hog-option pit. This pit was as small as a backyard Jacuzzi and so completely deserted you could follow all the steps. Mr. Epstein said this was one more example of the piteous decline in U.S. agriculture.

Mr. Flippen, Mr. Epstein, and I must have stood alone for nearly two minutes before a man with a red beard and an orange-and-white checkered jacket sauntered over from the direction of hog futures. His jacket would have attracted whatever business happened to be around, but in this case there was only me.

The man in the red beard introduced himself as Sonny Hersh. He seemed to be a thoughtful person, sober even, in contrast to his wardrobe. He looked to be about my age—40. Mr. Flippen handed him my order for one hog call.

"Pay 80 on one," Mr. Hersh yelled out to an empty pit. There was no immediate response. Soon a couple of idle traders moseyed over to sniff at the opportunity. "Eighty-five," Hersh yelled. Suddenly a young woman with badge LQ-001 appeared and made the